Hover states

In short

When a mouse pointer moves over a link or button, its look can change. If extra content appears, it must stay visible while the pointer moves onto it. People must also be able to close it with the Escape key.

What is it for?

Hover states are what happen when a mouse pointer moves over an interactive element. Interactive elements include things like links, buttons, and inputs.

Hover states must also follow all the usual accessibility guidelines. For instance, extra content might appear when someone hovers over or focuses on an element. It must stay visible while they move the pointer onto it, as screen magnifier users often need to do this to read it. They must also be able to dismiss it, for example with the Escape key. This is success criterion 1.4.13, Content on Hover or Focus, at Level AA of the Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG).

How to support it

If you're building or designing a new component, make sure it has hover states that follow all accessibility guidelines (for example, colour contrast, target size, descriptive text, and so on).

Useful links

- A whole lot of bovver over hover: problems with content that shows on hover
- Accessible button design
- Hover Actions and Accessibility: Addressing a Common WCAG Violation

Abbreviations

The full form of each abbreviation used in this document.

WCAG: Web Content Accessibility Guidelines